

a little shy when used as a semi-professional or professional tool. Also, if you're running any other Windows version apart from XP, forget about Premiere Elements 3.0—it's built only for XP Home and Professional!

4.2.2 CyberLink PowerDirector Premium

Most of us get CyberLink's PowerDVD Player along with our DVD-ROM/R/RW drives, and use the CyberLink DVD decoder to be able to view movie DVDs on our computers without giving a thought to who CyberLink is and what they do. Well, they also have a very professional video editing software called PowerDirector Premium, which is currently in version 5.

At US \$89.95 (Rs 4,300), it's a little cheaper than Premiere Elements, and at first look seems to offer much more. Let's take a look to see whether this holds true.

The first thing you'll come across is the software's "Magic" set of tools, which can be a real boon for the novice video editor. For example, the "Magic Cut" feature will automatically and intelligently chop a long video into little chunks of interesting content, for easier access to parts of your video. (WMM can do something like this, but the Magic Cut feature is more accurate.) Similarly, "Magic Fix" will automatically try and correct the image captured by a digital camera flash that caused red-eye in a subject, and even try and compensate for your shaking hands—auto-correcting the jittered look in videos.

The software also lets you specify a maximum time and size for video capturing, thus giving you ample control if you have space constraints on your hard drive.

As you have guessed, the software is really easy to use, and everything is quite apparent—menus are well placed, buttons are self-explanatory, and the majority of options are no more than two clicks away. It uses the drag-and-drop style of editing, which makes importing videos and moving them about a snap.